

Snowflake Applied AI:

Your Interview Process Guide (8 Pages)

Applied AI Engineer • Cortex AI Team • Menlo Park, CA

Welcome

This guide is designed to give you a clear picture of what to expect at each stage of our interview process. We believe you do your best work when you know what's coming — so we've tried to be as transparent as possible about format, focus, and how to prepare, without spoiling the experience itself.

Our process has seven stages. Some are remote, some are onsite. Each stage is designed to surface a specific signal, and together they give us a well-rounded picture of who you are as an engineer and as a colleague.

We've designed this process to be challenging but fair. Every stage is there for a reason, and every question is one we've thought carefully about. We want you to show us your best work — and we've tried to give you everything you need to do that. Good luck. We're looking forward to the conversation.

A NOTE ON OUR APPROACH

We don't do trick questions or gotcha puzzles. We're trying to understand how you actually think and work — not whether you can recall an obscure algorithm under pressure.

We also try to make this process feel like a two-way conversation. At every stage, you should be learning something real about us too.

What We Are Looking For

This role sits at the intersection of hands-on AI engineering and direct customer work. The people who thrive here tend to share a few qualities:

Quality	What it looks like in practice
Builder's instinct	You don't just understand AI concepts — you've shipped things with them. You're most comfortable when you're making something real.
Velocity under ambiguity	You make progress even when requirements are unclear. You make your assumptions explicit, move forward, and course-correct as you learn more.
Production mindset	You think about what happens after you ship: edge cases, failure modes, monitoring, cost. Demos are a starting point, not the finish line.
Customer empathy	You genuinely enjoy working with customers. You're comfortable translating complex technical tradeoffs into plain language and pushing back when expectations need resetting.
Honest self-assessment	You know what you're good at and what you're still learning. You're more interested in getting it right than in appearing to have all the answers.

A Few Things Worth Knowing

On AI tools

We use AI tools extensively in our own work and we expect you to as well — in most stages of this process. The exception is Stage 4, which is specifically designed to assess your baseline programming ability without assistance. Everywhere else, use the tools you'd normally use.

On your homework

Invest in it seriously. A strong submission with a thoughtful reflection document will serve you well for more than half of the process.

On honesty

We consistently find that candidates who are honest about what they don't know, what they'd do differently, and where they've struggled give us more confidence — not less. We're not looking for perfection. We're looking for self-awareness and a growth mindset.

**On the
onsite**

Stages 6 and 7 are in person where possible. Bring your laptop with your usual development tools configured. We'll provide everything else.

The Process at a Glance

#	Stage	Format	Primary focus
Virtual Technical Assessment			
3a	Homework Deep Dive	Remote · 60 min	Understanding your submission and technical depth
3b	Coding Fundamentals	Remote · 60 min	Programming fluency without AI assistance
3c	Customer Scoping Roleplay	Remote · 60 min	Customer communication and problem decomposition
Onsite Interview			
4a	AI Engineering Deep Dive	Onsite · 60 min	Live extension of your homework using AI tools
4b	Hiring Manager	Onsite · 60 min	Working style, values, and team fit
4c	Lunch with Team Member	Onsite · 60 min	Working style and team fit, any top-of-mind questions you'd like to ask.
Debrief, Offer Decision, & Reference Check Stage			

Next Rounds: Virtual Technical Interviews

(3 Interviews):

Interview 1

Homework Review

Remote · 60 minutes

What to expect

A deep-dive conversation about your take-home submission with one interviewer.

How to prepare

- Re-read your own code before the call. You should be able to speak fluently about every part of it.
- Be ready to explain why you made the architectural choices you did — not just what you built.
- Think about what you would improve or do differently with more time. Genuine self-awareness here is a strong signal.
- Don't memorize answers — we'll go wherever the conversation leads based on your submission.
- Be honest if there are parts of your submission you're not fully satisfied with. We respect candor.

What we are looking for

- That you genuinely understand what you built — not just that it works.
- Honest self-awareness about tradeoffs and gaps.
- Clear, structured thinking when explaining technical decisions.
- Evidence that you're using modern AI development tools in your workflow.

Interview 2

Coding Fundamentals

Remote • Live coding • 60 minutes

What to expect

A live coding session where you'll work through a programming problem with one interviewer observing. You can use any mainstream programming language. AI coding assistants are not permitted for this stage — we want to see your baseline programming fluency directly.

How to prepare

- Pick the language you are most comfortable in. There is no preferred language.
- Practice writing code by hand without autocomplete. Focus on clarity and correctness over cleverness.
- Talk through your thinking as you work. We want to follow your reasoning, not just see the output.
- Before you start coding, take a moment to understand the problem and plan your approach.
- Think about edge cases and error handling as you go — not just after the happy path works.

What we are looking for

- Solid programming fundamentals in your language of choice.
- Clean, readable code that handles edge cases thoughtfully.
- Clear narration of your thinking — we want to understand your decisions, not guess at them.
- The ability to recognize and recover from mistakes without losing momentum.

Extra Tips:

- Check out our new prep videos: [Interview Tips | How to Ace Your Coding Interview at Snowflake](#)
- Common LeetCode Topics: Graph Traversal, String Parsing, Top K Elements, Boundary of Binary Tree, and Count Vowel Substrings of a String. We recommend practicing for (Medium - Hard) Data Structures and Algorithmic questions.

Interview 3

Customer Scoping Roleplay

Remote • Roleplay + debrief • 60 minutes

What to expect

You'll be given a scenario at the start of the call and asked to step into the role of a Snowflake Applied AI Engineer meeting with a customer for the first time. The interviewer will play the customer. After approximately 45 minutes, we'll step out of the roleplay for a debrief conversation about how it went.

How to prepare

- Resist the urge to jump straight to solutions. Great customer conversations start with great questions.
- Think about what you don't know — and ask about it. Clarifying questions are a sign of strength, not weakness.
- Be prepared to push back respectfully when a customer's expectations or assumptions need challenging. Agreeing with everything is not a win.
- Practice breaking a vague problem into concrete, prioritized components.
- Think about how you'd explain a complex technical concept to someone who isn't an engineer.
- The debrief is as important as the roleplay — we'll ask how you think it went, so reflect honestly.

What we are looking for

- The ability to ask targeted questions before proposing solutions.
- Structured thinking — breaking a messy problem into clear workstreams.
- Confidence and diplomacy when managing scope or timeline expectations.
- Communication that adapts to a non-technical audience.

Onsite Interviews: (INFORMATIONAL PURPOSES ONLY, THE RECRUITER WILL GO OVER THIS WITH YOU LATER)

Stage 4a

AI Engineering Deep Dive

Onsite · Live coding · 60 minutes

What to expect

You'll be asked to solve a problem by writing code live, and AI coding tools are fully encouraged — use whatever you'd normally use. One interviewer will observe throughout. After the implementation, you'll write a short eval suite to verify your work, followed by a debrief.

How to prepare

- Bring your laptop
- Have your usual AI coding tools (Claude Code, Cursor, Copilot, etc.) configured and ready.
- Narrate your thinking out loud. The interviewer is watching how you work, not just what you ship.

What we are looking for

- How you orient and plan before diving into code.
- Effective, purposeful use of AI tools throughout the session.
- Consistent forward momentum — making progress and recovering quickly when something doesn't work.
- A testing mindset — writing meaningful tests that verify behavior, not just that the code runs.

Stage 4b

Hiring Manager Conversation

Onsite · 60 minutes

What to expect

A conversation with your hiring manager covering working style, how you handle challenging situations, and what it's like to be part of this team. We'll start by sharing context about the team and role, then move into a structured conversation. You'll have time at the end to ask us questions.

How to prepare

- Reflect on your career and come ready with specific examples — not hypotheticals. We'll ask about real situations.
- Think about times you've navigated ambiguity, received difficult feedback, made a meaningful mistake, or collaborated across teams with different priorities.
- Read about Snowflake's values before the conversation. We take them seriously and you'll see them come up naturally.
- Prepare thoughtful questions. The quality of your questions tells us as much as your answers.
- Be honest. We'd rather know who you really are than hear the answer you think we want.

What we are looking for

- How you handle ambiguity, feedback, failure, and cross-functional friction — with real examples.
- Alignment with Snowflake's values — especially ownership, integrity, and putting customers first.
- Genuine curiosity about the team, the work, and the challenges ahead.
- Self-awareness about your own working style and what you need to do your best work.